

Post-detection and SETI in Society: developments in 2025



(IAA SETI Committee Members: please see full written report for details, links, etc.)

Update for IAA SETI Committee, 1 Oct 2025, at IAC Sydney

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General Status

- Many SETI Committee members are interested in post-detection / discovery & society, although at present we aren't formally organized into a PD Sub-Committee within the Committee.
- Meanwhile, considerable work and discussion relevant to PD continues.
- In late 2022 a small task group started work specifically on Protocols revisions. Today we continue the discussion about our new draft version of the *“Declaration of Principles Concerning the Conduct of the Search for ExtraTerrestrial Intelligence (SETI)”* – subsequent presentations
- Intense interest continues in “discovery and society” issues for ETL and ETI for good reasons, including the proliferation of potential discovery types and an increasingly complicated and risky communication landscape.

Overview

- A brief general comment about context and history
- And now, in 2025....
- Abstracts related to Post-detection in 2025 IAC SETI sessions
- Some relevant recent and upcoming activities of SETI PC members
- See my full written report for list of recent relevant publications
- Relevant NASA initiatives
- The Protocols: a Draft Revised “*Declaration of Principles Concerning the Conduct of the Search for ExtraTerrestrial Intelligence (SETI)*” - M. Garrett and L. Tennen will present details, just brief comments from me:
 - Thanks to all for participating; Potential future Best Practices Guidelines, and Post-Detection subcommittee resurrection / Committee membership renewal

Context and history

This Committee founded in 1974 after many preliminary discussions/one-time meetings with IAA/IAC

Committee's first Chair, Rudolf Pešek (Czechoslovakia), reviewed ten years of IAA CETI work from 1965-1976: emphasized that the essential function of the Committee was to bridge between the CETI programs of different nations, noting that the work was **"by its very nature, international in character both as regards its possible accomplishment and its implication for all mankind."** (Pešek 1979:3) This was his vision from the beginning: to unify conversations about CETI which were otherwise taking place only inside national borders. *It was not easy to do.* (See my full report.)

Pešek also emphasized a constant – that starting with the earliest IAA CETI discussions in 1965, **the impact of CETI on humanity was recognized as an essential subject for discussion at international symposia, in tandem with the science. He also emphasized the need to involve the UN.**



Rudolf Pešek, 1965

From Radulescu 2025

<https://airandspace.si.edu/stories/editorial/radio-universe-cold-war-communication>



John Rummel, NASA's HRMS Program Scientist.

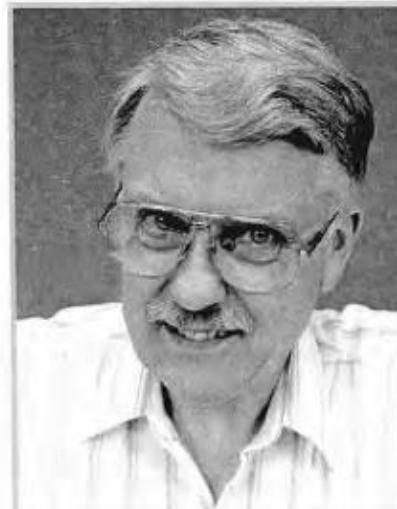


John Billingham, Co-chair of the Working Group and Head of the NASA SETI program at Ames Research Center, Moffett Field, California.

Social Implications of the Detection of an Extraterrestrial Civilization

A Report of the Workshops on the Cultural Aspects of SETI

Held in three sessions:
October 1991, May 1992, and September 1992
at Santa Cruz, California



Mike Klein, of the Jet Propulsion Lab.



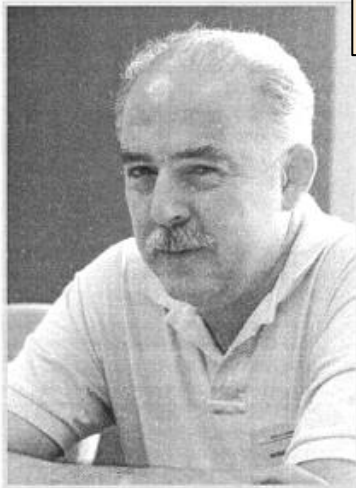
Tom Pierson, Executive Director of the SETI Institute.

Report published 1999, SETI Press. Spot the original Protocols authors and Chairs/Co-Chairs of this Committee :)
Photos included in report, all by Seth Shostak

Edited by: John Billingham, Roger Heyns, David Milne, Stephen Doyle, Michael Klein, John Heilbron, Michael Ashkenazi, Michael Michaud, Julie Lutz, and Seth Shostak



Andy Fraknoi, Executive Director of the Astronomical Society of the Pacific and Chair of the Foothill College Astronomy Department.



Michael Michaud, the Counselor for Science, Technology and Environment at the American Embassy in Paris.



Ben Finney, anthropologist at the University of Hawaii.



Steven J. Dick, historian at the U.S. Naval Observatory.



Jill Tarter, HRMS Project Scientist with the SETI Institute.



Nandi Jasentuliyana, Director of the United Nations Office for Outer Space Affairs.



John Billingham, Co-chair of the Working Group and Head of the NASA SETI program at Ames Research Center, Moffett Field, California.

General Chairman
JOHN BILLINGHAM (USA)

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MICHAEL ASHKENAZI (Israel)
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Local Organizing Comm. Chair
JEAN HEIDMANN (France)

Conference Organization Chair
THOMAS PIERSON (USA)

International Academy of Astronautics
SETI Committee

1995 INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE ON SETI AND SOCIETY

June 11-17, 1995 – Chamonix, France

VERA BUESCHER, *Conference Coordinator*, SETI Institute, 2035 Landings Drive, Mountain View, CA 94043 USA PHONE: 1-415-961-6633; FAX 1-415-961-7099



Stephen Doyle, Past Chair of the International Academy of Astronautics Social Sciences Section, and member of the International Institute of Space Law.



Vera Buescher of the SETI Institute, the Workshop Coordinator.



Michael Ashkenazi, of the Ben Gurion University.



Tom Pierson, Executive Director of the SETI Institute.

Above: Letterhead from the eventually **cancelled** Chamonix conference
- Billingham files, SETI Inst

Photos of organizers are from the *Social Implications* report, 1999, Billingham et al. (photos: S. Shostak)

So now in 2025?

- Even though things didn't go according to the original plan...
- the SETI research community kept alive the principle that interdisciplinary work and international intentions both matter, and periodically convened smaller workshops on these themes. (Doug Vakoch in particular!)
- now, in the 2020s, the next generation of researchers is taking up the challenge with new energy and vision.
- conversations and research on the social implications and cultural aspects of SETI and astrobiology happen in many places: the IAC is only one such place
- so, we must continue to work to connect and bridge those conversations in a spirit of collaboration – but this task is getting bigger!

So now in 2025? cont'd

- while technosignatures searches continue to intensify and expand (as covered in other reports to the Committee), the societal and media impact of potential discoveries continues to be evident
- (so far) this year, several putative discoveries of evidence of extraterrestrial life have provoked headlines and debates: the interstellar object 3I/ATLAS, the exoplanet K2-18b, and the Perseverance rover's Sapphire Canyon rock sample on Mars ... the patterns are by now familiar ... and this underscores the importance of ongoing discussions about how these situations are best handled by the international community of scientists and science communicators
- Work in this area is intensifying with respect to both biosignatures and technosignatures science and to their zones of overlap ... and this is the context for our update of the *Declaration of Principles*
- Beyond the *Declaration*, we will need additional guidelines, e.g. safety for scientists, best practices for science and risk communication for SETI, etc.

Coming soon...

- Next year's report in 2026 will incorporate some new elements, including **an imminent new development within the SETI Institute**. The SETI Institute is pleased to confirm that starting in autumn 2025, there will be a new sustained research initiative within their Carl Sagan Center for Research, focused upon 'discovery and society', encompassing SETI, astrobiology, post-detection, science communication, and related topics.
- Lucian Walkowicz and Chelsea Haramia will be co-directors and I (Kathryn Denning) will be senior advisor.
- This initiative is the culmination of years of planning and builds on the Institute's strengths and the legacies of its founders and members, including several previous Chairs and Co-Chairs of the IAA SETI Committee.
- We look forward to sharing more details with the SETI community soon, and to building a new concentration of interdisciplinary, international, anticipatory, collaborative research on subjects of direct relevance to the Committee, and, of course, to cooperation with related international initiatives.
- You'll be hearing from us :)
- *P.s. We're excited and energetic but this is a small, part-time initiative, so we can't solve everything!!*

Abstracts related to Post-Detection at IAC 2025

See <https://iafastro.directory/iac/browse/IAC-25/A4/> for the symposium listings and see the IAFastro Digital Library to search for full papers / proceedings: <https://dl.iafastro.directory/>

- **C. Oliver and S. Shostak:** The case of the EQ Peg hoax 25 years ago: Would a replay in today's media landscape have the same result? [Abstract](#) and [Paper](#)
- **L. Walton:** “The history of the IAA SETI Permanent Committee – 2000-2009” [Abstract](#) and [Paper](#)
- **M. Garrett, K. Denning, L.I. Tenning, C. Oliver:** “SETI Post-Detection Protocols: Progress Towards a New Version” [Abstract](#) and [Paper](#)
- **D. De Paulis, M.L. Jensvold, N. Cabrol** (withdrawn): “Patterns in Perception of a Simulated Message from Space” [Abstract](#)
- **A. Harrington:** “The International Institute of Space Law SETI Working Group: Introduction, Overview, and Findings So Far” [Abstract](#) and [Paper](#)
- **S. Shagun** (withdrawn): “The Societal and Legal Consequences of Detecting Extraterrestrial Intelligence: A Governance Gap” [Abstract](#)
- **K. Genevieve:** “Refiguring Communication in SETI: Cybernetics, Analogy, and Improvisation in the Search for Extraterrestrial Life” [Abstract](#) and [Paper](#)

Abstracts related to Post-Detection at IAC 2025, cont'd

- **S. Alexander:** “Space and Interstellar Travel and What We Want to be Remembered For – The Case for Indigenous Knowledges for Communication with Prospective ET’s and for Human spaceflight purpose and a Collective Earth Message” [Abstract](#) and [Paper](#)
- **P. Musso:** “A first contribution to the history of Italian SETI” [Abstract](#) and [Paper](#)
- **A. D. Harvey and D. Wood:** “New Cosmic Perspectives: Indigenous Knowledge and SETI” [Abstract](#) and [Paper](#)
- **C. Haramia:** “Sustainability Puzzles and the Extraterrestrial Turn” [Abstract](#) and [Paper](#)
- **A. Mohite and S. Ankam:** “Beyond Human Bias: Developing Non-Anthropocentric Methods for Detecting Extraterrestrial Intelligence” [Abstract](#)
- **N. Kerketta:** “Differences in linguistic cultural and moral values of a similarly intelligent extraterrestrial life-form” [Abstract](#)
- **D. De Paulis and A. Melis (withdrawn):** “A Single Sky: a new simulated First-Contact scenario engaging the global scientific SETI network, and integrating deep space technologies into SETI search.” [Abstract](#)

Abstracts related to Post-Detection at IAC 2025, cont'd

- **K. Bayramova:** “The role of consciousness in defining reality: a philosophical and scientific inquiry” [Abstract](#)
- **E. Norton-Fox:** “Earth’s first encounter. Will making contact strengthen humanity or cause more harm than good, and if so, who makes the first move?” [Abstract](#)
- **R. Alazzam et al:** “ The Search for Meaning: The Social Impact of SETI and Its Influence on Humanity” [Abstract](#)
- **P. Musso, N. Antonietti et al:** “Five years of SETI at the InCosmiCon Research Center” [Abstract](#)
- **S. Raviraja:** “Artificial Human Evolved Intelligence vs. Naturally Evolved Biological Intelligence: Interaction between the two and Game Theory” [Abstract](#)

Some PD-relevant activities of SETI Committee members, recent and upcoming

N.b. This compilation is not comprehensive. Please do share your updates/information with me.

- Continued public outreach by SETI Institute and Breakthrough Listen, continued public engagement by other SETI projects
- PSETI: [seminar series](#), [OotO](#), and PSETI Symposium 2025 had many PD-related talks and breakout sessions involving multiple Committee members
- [Technosignatures Seminar Series](#) at NASA Goddard
- InCosmiCon (P. Musso et al)
- Daniela de Paulis and team, *A Sign in Space*
- IISL SETI & Law Working Group, A. Harrington, multiple Committee members involved
- ASPIRE One, Anamaria Berea and team
- Cosmic Footprint Society project
- AbSciCon 2026 (we usually have interdisciplinary sessions)
- IAUS 404 (J. Haqq-Misra and other Committee members)

SETI Post-Detection Hub

- Coordinator: John Elliott john.elliott@st-andrews.ac.uk , longtime SETI Committee member
- a [UKSRN](#) initiative, is jointly hosted by the [St Andrews Centre for Exoplanet Science](#) (led by Committee member Martin Dominik and Emily Finer), the Centre for Global Law and Governance, the Durham Law School, and the Jodrell Bank Centre for Astrophysics of U. Manchester
- Membership has grown since Nov 2022 launch: now >50 researchers (fairly even split UK/international), including multiple members of the IAA SETI Committee. Some have worked on SETI topics for many years, others are newer to the subject but bring significant interdisciplinary expertise e.g. sci comm research, public policy, risk, etc. Collaborations are coalescing: reading groups and regular meetings help.
- Current endeavours include: funding applications (for projects and for the Hub as a centre); student networks; participation in British and Irish Science Festivals; conference participation; discussions with UK government; media (filming, interviews, articles); and a small in-person workshop in summer 2025 in St. Andrews; a group white paper for the NASA-DARES RFI
- Scenarios work over the past two years (G. Profitiliotis leading): a tool from Futures Studies/strategic foresight for thinking about possible futures 5-25 years from now, and building *futures literacy*. A future SETI detection would take place in a different social/technological world, effectively. Work continues on the Post-Detection Toolkit, with many members collaborating. Stay tuned...

NASA Astrobio Program

- Please see written report. Despite significant challenges for NASA, the NAP is maintaining an interest in “discovery communications”.
- 2024 workshop “*Communicating Discoveries in the Search for Life in the Universe*” report will be out soon in *Astrobiology* and on ArXiv: participants and authors included technosignatures researchers and members of this Committee. The report is of clear relevance to the technosignatures / post-detection community. A special note re: safety for scientists. This is included in the report, and is also the focus of a UNESCO office and report now. (refs in report)
- The [NASA Decadal Astrobiology Research and Exploration Strategy](#) process is now underway. Notably, the [2024 RFI](#) included the topic “Prepare for the Discovery of Life Beyond Earth and Subsequent Post-Discovery Activities” several White Papers submitted in early 2025, and summarized in the May 2025 RFI Findings Workshop by DARES Task Force 1 member Jordan Bimm under “Astrobiology and Society” – see recording [here](#) at time 2:30:10. (And see presentations by Sofia Sheikh and Anamaria Berea.) We’ll see how the DARES process goes...

Protocols: a Draft Revised *Declaration* to discuss

- The Protocols task group (C. Oliver, K. Denning, L. Tennen, M. Garrett) has produced a new Draft Revised “*Declaration of Principles Concerning the Conduct of the Search for ExtraTerrestrial Intelligence*”, which Committee members have received. Thanks to all for your input and collegiality. M. Garrett and L. Tennen will discuss further.
- Aspects of the Draft that we might discuss today? after Mike and Les present:
 - The Preamble includes the idea of ‘**Best Practices Guidelines**’ to accompany the Declaration of Principles
 - these could be less formal, produced by a small working group for each topic, and more frequently updated. *E.g.* Best Practices for: safety for scientists, science and risk communication re: technosignatures; projects with students; for projects with citizen scientists; for data handling; for discoveries of physical objects in the solar system....
 - **Post-Detection Sub-Committee**
 - Existed from ~1996-2014, but not for the past 10 years. Varying activities, remits, and ToR in the past – worth reviewing before we set new ToR and expectations
 - We should reflect on current overall Committee composition (including expertises, gender and age representation), who we need to add, and what a PD SubComm could really achieve. Some potential activities require expertise that we may not have at sufficient levels, and/or would realistically require funding. Much needs to be done, but the SETI Committee can’t realistically do it all.